

The mention Package

Ashwani Anand

Version 0.1.0 – 2026/05/12

Abstract

The `mention` package adds targeted collaborative comments on top of `phfcc`. Comments remain visible inline in the source document, while only the addressed collaborator sees margin highlights and a header summary of unresolved comments for the active viewer.

Contents

1	Introduction	2
2	Installation	2
3	Defining Authors	2
3.1	The author command factory	2
3.2	Default colors	3
4	Writing Comments	3
5	Viewer Selection	3
5.1	Direct handle selection	3
5.2	User-id selection	4
5.3	Explicit user-id mappings	4
5.4	Local Configuration	4
5.5	Automatic Detection	4
6	Header Summary	5
6.1	The standard header	5
7	Complete Example	5
8	Public Interface	6
9	Limitations	6
10	License	6

1 Introduction

Collaborative drafts often need comments that are visible in context but routed to a specific co-author. The `mention` package provides one command per author, a recipient list for each comment, optional important-comment styling, and a resolved flag that keeps old comments visible without counting them as open work.

The package is intentionally small. It depends on `phfcc` for the base commenting environment and on common LaTeX packages for colors, margin notes, and command parsing. Automatic viewer detection is best-effort; projects that need the most predictable behavior should use a local `mention-local.cfg` file.

2 Installation

Place `mention.sty` where TeX can find it. For a single project, putting the file next to the main `.tex` document is enough:

```
project/  
  paper.tex  
  mention.sty  
  mention-local.cfg.example
```

Then load the package with:

```
\usepackage{mention}
```

The package requires `phfcc`, `xparse`, `xcolor`, and `marginnote`. The optional automatic viewer detection path can use `catchfile` and `texosquery` when they are available.

3 Defining Authors

3.1 The author command factory

Define one author command per collaborator:

```
\phfMakeTargetedCommentCommand[  
  initials={AL},  
  handle=alice,  
  userid=alice-laptop  
{\Alice}
```

This defines a command named `\Alice`. Its comments are printed inline using the configured color. If a comment targets the active viewer, a margin note is also printed using the author's initials.

Option	Meaning
<code>initials</code>	Short text printed in margin notes.
<code>color</code>	Any color expression accepted by <code>xcolor</code> .
<code>handle</code>	Stable collaborator handle used in recipient lists.
<code>userid</code>	Optional system user id mapped to the handle.

If `initials` is omitted, the command name is used. If `handle` is omitted, the lower-cased command name is used. If `color` is omitted, the package chooses the next color from its built-in colorblind-friendly cycle.

3.2 Default colors

When `color` is omitted, `mention` assigns an author color automatically. If the `colorblind` package is available, the default cycle uses private copies of Paul Tol’s muted T-Q-M1 through T-Q-M9 colors. `mention` loads `colorblind` with `Tol,keep-defaults,no-tikz`, so default document colors such as `red`, `green`, or `blue` are not changed.

If `colorblind` is missing, or was already loaded without defining the T-Q-M colors, `mention` falls back to its built-in `xcolor` palette. Explicit author colors always take precedence:

```
\phfMakeTargetedCommentCommand[
  initials={AL},
  color=blue!60!black,
  handle=alice
]{Alice}
```

4 Writing Comments

Comments use the optional argument for recipient handles:

```
\Alice[bob]{Please check this lemma.}
\Alice[bob, claire]{Please verify this proof.}
\Alice![bob]{Please add the missing citation.}
\Alice[all]{Everyone should review this sentence.}
\Alice[bob, resolved]{This has already been handled.}
\Alice[all, resolved]{This global note is done.}
```

The form with `!` marks a comment as important. Important comments use a stronger filled margin label for the active viewer.

The special recipient-list item `all` routes a comment to every active viewer. Every viewer who compiles the document sees the margin note and gets the comment included in their unresolved-count total.

The special recipient-list item `resolved` makes a comment dormant. It still appears inline, but it is not routed to anyone, does not get a margin note, and does not contribute to unresolved counts. If `all` and `resolved` are both present, `resolved` wins.

Consecutive comments for the active viewer share one side-by-side margin note. This keeps co-authors who comment at the same spot from covering each other in the margin.

5 Viewer Selection

5.1 Direct handle selection

Set the active viewer directly by handle:

```
\phfSetViewer{bob}
```

5.2 User-id selection

Set the active viewer by user id. If the user id was registered through an author's `userid` option, it maps to that author's handle:

```
\phfSetViewerUser{bob-laptop}
```

5.3 Explicit user-id mappings

Register or override an explicit user-id mapping:

```
\phfRegisterViewerUser{bob-laptop}{bob}
```

Viewer selection is resolved in this order:

1. an explicit `\phfSetViewer{...}` call;
2. an explicit `\phfSetViewerUser{...}` call;
3. a local `mention-local.cfg` file, if present;
4. best-effort automatic detection.

5.4 Local Configuration

For shared Git repositories, the recommended workflow is to keep `mention-local.cfg` ignored and let each collaborator create their own copy from `mention-local.cfg.example`.

```
cp mention-local.cfg.example mention-local.cfg
```

A local config can select a handle:

```
\phfSetViewer{bob}
```

or a user id:

```
\phfSetViewerUser{bob-laptop}
```

The package loads `mention-local.cfg` automatically when the document starts.

5.5 Automatic Detection

When no explicit viewer is set, `mention` tries to infer the compiling user. With shell access, it first asks `kpsewhich` for common user variables: `USER`, `USERNAME`, and `LOGNAME`. If that does not work and `texosquery` is available, it tries to derive a user id from the home-directory path.

This detection path is best-effort. It may be unavailable on systems that disable shell escape or do not ship the optional helper packages. Manual viewer selection through `mention-local.cfg` does not require shell escape.

6 Header Summary

6.1 The standard header

Enable a centered page-header summary:

```
\phfUseTargetedCommentHeader
```

The summary reports unresolved comments for the active viewer, for example:

```
There are 2 unresolved comments for you.
```

The count is written through the .aux file. Compile twice after changing comments or viewer selection.

7 Complete Example

```
\documentclass{article}
\usepackage[margin=1in]{geometry}
\setlength{\marginparwidth}{3cm}
\usepackage{xcolor}
\usepackage{mention}

\phfMakeTargetedCommentCommand[
  initials={AL},
  color=blue,
  handle=alice,
  userid=alice-laptop
]{Alice}

\phfMakeTargetedCommentCommand[
  initials={BO},
  color=orange,
  handle=bob,
  userid=bob-laptop
]{Bob}

\phfUseTargetedCommentHeader

\begin{document}

We should revise this proof
\Alice[bob]{Please check the induction step.}
before submission.

\Alice![bob]{Please add the missing citation.}
\Alice[bob, resolved]{This earlier point is done.}

\end{document}
```

8 Public Interface

Command	Purpose
<code>\phfMakeTargetedCommentCommand</code>	define an author command
<code>\phfSetViewer</code>	select the active viewer by handle
<code>\phfSetViewerUser</code>	select the active viewer by user id
<code>\phfRegisterViewerUser</code>	map a user id to a handle
<code>\phfUseTargetedCommentHeader</code>	install the standard header
<code>\phfTargetedCommentSummary</code>	typeset only the summary text

The author-command factory has the form:

```
\phfMakeTargetedCommentCommand[options]{CommandName}
```

The viewer commands have the forms:

```
\phfSetViewer{handle}
\phfSetViewerUser{userid}
\phfRegisterViewerUser{userid}{handle}
```

9 Limitations

The response-marker commands

```
\phfMarkCommentResponded
\phfccDeclareResponded
```

are retained only as compatibility stubs and emit a warning. Use the `resolved` flag in a comment recipient list instead.

The package does not hide inline comments from non-recipients. Targeting only controls margin notes and unresolved counts.

10 License

Copyright © 2026 Ashwani Anand.

This work may be distributed and/or modified under the conditions of the LaTeX Project Public License, either version 1.3c of this license or any later version.

This work has the LPPL maintenance status `maintained`.

The Current Maintainer of this work is Ashwani Anand.

This work consists of the files `README.md`, `mention.tex`, `mention.sty`, `mention-local.cfg.example`, and `targeted-comments-demo.tex`, and the derived files `mention.pdf` and `targeted-comments-demo.pdf`.